

Jonah and the Whale

The Lord spoke to Jonah and told him to go to the great city of Nineveh. The people there were doing wrong, and Jonah was commanded to warn them to change their ways. But Jonah did not want to go. Nineveh was far away, and its people were enemies of Jonah's own nation. Instead of obeying, Jonah decided to run.

He went down to the seaport and found a ship sailing in the opposite direction. He paid his fare, boarded the ship, and went below deck, hoping to escape from what he had been told to do.

As the ship sailed, a powerful storm suddenly rose. The wind howled, and the waves grew larger and more dangerous. The ship was tossed back and forth, and the sailors feared it would break apart. They cried out for help and threw their cargo into the sea to lighten the load.

Jonah, however, was fast asleep in the lower part of the ship. The captain found him and shouted, "How can you sleep at a time like this? Get up and pray! Maybe your God will spare us."

The sailors decided to cast lots to discover who was responsible for the storm. When they did, the lot fell on Jonah. They questioned him closely, asking who he was and what he had done. Jonah admitted that he was running away from the Lord, the God who created the sea and the land.

The sailors were terrified. "What should we do to you so the sea will calm down?" they asked.

Jonah answered, "Pick me up and throw me into the sea. Then it will become calm, for I know this storm has come because of me."

The sailors tried to row back to land, but the storm only grew worse. Finally, they prayed for forgiveness and threw Jonah into the sea. At once, the wind stopped, and the water became calm. The sailors were amazed and offered thanks to the Lord.

Jonah sank into the deep. The waters closed over him, and he was pulled downward into darkness. But the Lord sent a great whale to swallow Jonah, and Jonah remained inside the whale for three days and three nights.

From inside the whale, Jonah prayed. He cried out for help and promised to obey the Lord. He remembered that salvation comes from God alone. The Lord heard Jonah's prayer, and the whale vomited Jonah onto dry land.

Once again, the Lord spoke to Jonah and told him to go to Nineveh and deliver the warning he had been given. This time, Jonah obeyed.

Nineveh was an enormous city, taking three days to walk through. Jonah entered the city and began to proclaim that in forty days, the city would be destroyed. The people of Nineveh listened. They believed the warning, turned away from their wrongdoing, and asked for mercy. From the poorest person to the king himself, they humbled themselves and sought forgiveness.

When God saw that the people had changed their ways, He showed compassion and chose not to destroy the city.

Jonah was deeply upset by this. He prayed angrily, saying that this was why he had run away in the first place. He knew that God was merciful and forgiving, and he did not want Nineveh to be spared. Jonah said he would rather die than see the city saved.

Jonah went outside the city and sat in the hot sun, watching to see what would happen. The Lord caused a plant to grow beside Jonah, giving him shade and comfort. Jonah was pleased.

But the next day, the Lord sent a worm to destroy the plant, and it withered. The sun beat down on Jonah's head, and he became miserable. Again, Jonah said he wished he were dead.

The Lord asked Jonah if it was right for him to be angry over the plant. Jonah said it was.

Then the Lord said that Jonah had cared about the plant, even though he did nothing to make it grow. Should God not care even more for a great city like Nineveh, with thousands of people who needed guidance?